hidden feature of our government—but also to his representative character as Eisenhower's former Undersecretary of State.

The importance of the individuals in the circle becomes clear as one reflects on the extraordinary role they played. Decisions passed through the President's hand but were not simply the product of his mind alone. Both the definition of the issue and the choice of the U.S. response *emerged* from deliberations of the group. Robert Kennedy's account is suggestive, both about individual perceptions and preferences, and about the process by which the group came to the blockade.[*]

On the morning of Tuesday, October 16, McGeorge Bundy went to the President's living quarters with the message: "Mr. President, there is now hard photographic evidence that the Russians have offensive missiles in Cuba." Much has been made of Kennedy's "expression of surprise." But "surprise" fails to capture the character of his initial reaction. Rather it was one of startled anger, most adequately conveyed by the exclamation: "He can't do that to *me!*" That exclamation in this context was triple-barreled. First, in terms of the President's attention and priorities at the moment, Khrushchev had chosen the most unhelpful act of all. In a highly sensitive domestic political context—less than two years after the Bay of Pigs, less than two months before midterm elections—where his opponents demanded action against Soviet interests in Cuba, Kennedy was following a policy of reason and responsibility. In support of that policy, he had drawn a distinction between "defensive" and "offensive" weapons, staked his full presidential authority on the flat statement that the Soviets were not placing offensive weapons in Cuba, and warned unambiguously that offensive missiles would not be tolerated. Second, the main thrust of his Administration's policy toward the Soviet Union had been aimed at relaxing tension and building trust through trust. At considerable political cost, he was attempting to leash the anti-Communist cold warriors and to educate officials, as well as the public, out of prevailing devil theories of Soviet Communism. He and his closest advisers had made considerable effort to guarantee that all communication between the President and the Chairman would be straightforward and accurate. Contact had been made; Khrushchev was reciprocating; mutual confidence was growing. As part of this exchange, Khrushchev had assured the President through the most direct and personal channels that he was aware of Kennedy's domestic problem and would do nothing to complicate it. Specifically, Khrushchev had given the President solemn assurances that the Soviet Union would not put offensive missiles in Cuba. But then this—the Chairman had *lied* to the